

IT Research Methodology

Qualitative Data Collection

Image Source: Research Methodology

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Outline

- Qualitative Collecting Data
- Interview Protocol
- Observation

❖ Qualitative Collecting Data

- Forms of Data
  - ✓ Observations
  - ✓ Interviews
  - ✓ Documents
  - ✓ Auto-Visual Materials

❖ Interview Protocol

➢ An interview protocol serves the purpose of reminding you of the questions and provides a means for recording notes.

Project: University Reaction to a Gunman Incident

Time of Interview:
Date:
Place:
Interviewer:
Interviewee:
Position of Interviewee:

[Describe here the project, telling the interviewee about (a) the purpose of the study, (b) the individuals and sources of data being collected, (c) what will be done with the data to protect the confidentiality of the interviewee, and (d) how long the interview will take.]
[Have the interviewee read and sign the consent form.]
[Turn on the recorder and test it.]

Questions:

1. Please describe your role in the incident.
2. What has happened since the event that you have been involved in?
3. What has been the impact on the University community of this incident?
4. What larger ramifications, if any, exist from the incident?
5. Whom should we talk to to find out more about campus reaction to the incident?

(Thank the individuals for their cooperation and participation in this interview. Assure them of the confidentiality of the responses and the potential for future interviews.)

❖ Observation

- Select a site to be observed
- Identify a gatekeeper who can give you access to the site
- Identify who will be observed and for how long
- Determine your role as an observer

❖ Observation

➢ Gatekeepers

❖ Individual who provides entrance to a site and helps locate potential participants

❖ May be a person in an official of unofficial role, e.g.,

✓ Superintendent of the school

✓ Principles and teachers

✓ Head of human resources

❖ Observation

➢ Type of observations

- Complete Participant
- Participant/Participant as Observer
  - You are participating in the activity at the site
    - Participant role is more salient than researcher role
    - Difficult to record data
  - Insider role/ “subjective”
- Nonparticipant/Observer as participant
  - Recording data without direct involvement with activity/participants
    - Watching/taking fieldnotes from a distance
  - Outsider role/ “objective”

❖ Observation

➢ Type of observations (Cont.)

- Complete Observer

You can change your role during an observation

Start as nonparticipant then move into participant

Start as outsider at the beginning and become an insider over time

Observation

- What do you observe?
  - Based on purpose, research questions
  - Physical sitting: space, objects
  - Participants: who, number of participants, and their roles
  - Activities and interactions: Sequence/timing of behavior, rules
  - Conversations: quotes, paraphrase
  - Subtle factors: Nonverbal communication, what does not happen, unusual
  - Your own behavior: position and activities, social location, reflections

❖ Observation

➢ How do you observe?

- ❖ Know that writing down everything is IMPOSSIBLE
- ❖ Use your senses: sight, hearing, touch, smell, taste
- ❖ Start broadly and then narrow your focus/concentrate on research questions
- ❖ Focus on detail/depth
- ❖ Limit your time

❖ Observation

- Design an observational protocol
- Record aspects such as portraits of the informant, the physical setting, particular events and activities
- During the observation have someone introduce you as outsider
- Summarize what you have observed shortly after each observation or at the end of each day
- Develop a log of activities
- After observing slowly, draw a way from the site

❖ Observation

➢ Design an observational protocol

- The header:
  - ✓ Contains essential information about the project including the purpose
  - ✓ Include essential information about the interview including the participant's name, date time of the interview and location of the interview
- Leave space at the top to include a visual sketch of the setting
- Divide the protocol into two columns of descriptive notes and reflective notes

❖ Observation

➢ Record observational field notes

- Prepare your full notes immediately after the observation
  - Expect to take long or longer filling and expanding your notes as you spend observing.
    - Complete sentences, good grammar
    - Thick, rich narrative description (i.e. detail)
    - Context – time, place, etc.
    - Headings/dividers
    - Flow – beginning, middle, end
    - Visual aids (drawings, maps) clearly labeled
- May want to use pseudonyms/abbreviations instead of participant names in your fieldnotes
  - Keep a separate log linking the two

❖ Observation

➢ Field issues:

- ❖ Assuming an observational role
- ❖ Being overwhelmed with information from the site
- ❖ Reducing information from a broad picture to a narrow picture
- ❖ Maintaining relationships at the site

Observation

Field Issues in Qualitative Research	
Access	
◆ gaining access to the site and individuals ◆ getting people to respond to requests for information	◆ deciding whether to collect information in the natural site ◆ determining whether one has sufficient "distance" to site
Observations	
◆ determining whether fieldnotes are credible ◆ writing down "jottings" ◆ incorporating "quotes" into fieldnotes ◆ assuming an observer role and how to change roles	◆ learning how to best collect information from early field visits in case studies ◆ learning how to "funnel" from broad observations to narrow ones

Observation

Interviews

- saying little during interview
- scheduling a time for all to participate in a group interview
- matching the level of questions to the ability of informants
- realizing the costliness and lengthy process of transcribing data
- using an appropriate level of questioning at the beginning of the interview
- interruptions during an interview
- difficulty scheduling an interview
- having confidence in interviewing skills
- having difficulty taking notes while interviewing
- conducting interviews with two or more individuals
- encouraging all participants to talk in a group interview
- asking appropriate questions
- learning to listen rather than talk in interviews
- handling emotional outbursts
- addressing participants who do not want to be recorded
- finding a transcriptionist and the right type of equipment in a case study and grounded theory project
- moving from icebreakers to questions in the interview
- addressing when interviewees stray from the questions
- giving the interview questions to participants before the interview
- working with the logistics of the recording equipment
- “bracketing” personal bias
- focusing the questions to ask in a group interview

Observation

Documents	
◆ having difficulty locating materials ◆ having difficulty obtaining permission to use materials ◆ having people write complete journal entries ◆ having difficulty reading handwritten journals	◆ having informants express the difficulty of journaling ◆ questioning the value of materials ◆ having informants ask questions about how one might journal
Audiovisual Materials	
◆ having disruptive room sounds ◆ having problems video recording in a small room	◆ having difficulties focusing and positioning the camera

Source: Adapted from Creswell and Poth (2018).

❖ Observation

➢ Conducting an observation:

- Place: (image)
- Length of observation: 20 minutes
- Observe to collect data on this research topic: what can a people tell us about activities in the image?

- Decide on what you will observe – select one site/place
- Decide what your role in observation will be – from complete participant to complete non-participant or changing
- Start broadly not trying to record every thing – then narrow (ZOOM LENS)
- Record your notes – fieldnotes on and observation protocol (use the layout below to design your observational protocol)
- Record descriptive notes (just the facts of what you see) and reflective notes (potential themes), for example.
  - Create a chronology of what you see by time
  - Look for: what one expects to find, what was surprising to find, what was unusual to find
- Write fieldnotes
- Write detail on complete sentences
- Record quotes from individual if you have them

Q&A